Imagining, Sharing, or Deferring Futures for Collections?

Montage and *Pro Tempore* Custody as Methods

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Remarks read on October 1, 2026, at the Fundación Federico Jorge Klemm, Buenos Aires, during the signing of the loan agreement and the trial installation of *Un meteorito para la Sociedad Científica* Argentina [A Meteorite for the Argentine Scientific Society in the Year 2105, by Faivovich & Goldberg]

Good afternoon, and welcome to this intimate ceremony marking the incorporation—as a loan for use—of the central piece of the work *Un meteorito para la Sociedad Científica Argentina del año 2105*, by Faivovich & Goldberg, into the Collection of the Fundación Klemm.

> "Mounting" this piece in our gallery is also a method. The method of montage: bringing together fragments that come from different times and places and allowing something new to become visible in their proximity. This afternoon we wish to make visible a concern and a conviction: that conscious actions in the present contribute to a future we invite you to imagine together.

I. Federico and His Desire: The Foundation That Bears His Name

Federico Klemm was born into a migrant family. As a child and adolescent, lost among languages, he first found in the stage and the cinema a space of expression of his own. He later practiced performance and opera, and became a cultural animator, a patron, and the screenwriter, producer, and host of 232 television programs devoted to the visual arts (*El Banquete Telemático* [The Telematic Banquet]), at the time sometimes received as an extravagance; today, a cult program.

Between 1992 and 1995 he founded and directed Galería Klemm, where he championed a local collecting of contemporary art that had no market at the time. In 1995 he established the Foundation that bears his name: a home for his Collection, which today comprises more than 760 works and which, true to his premise, is permanently on view, through a variety of curatorial perspectives and always with free admission.

Beyond his actions, it is important to mention his pioneering way of thinking about his collection and his legacy: enjoying the present without neglecting, for a single minute, its projection and his vision of the future. In 1999, "in full possession of his physical and mental faculties," he wrote his will in his own hand. The text is direct: **the National Academy of Fine Arts (Academia Nacional de Bellas Artes, ANBA) will in the future act as administrative overseer, and the collection, once the funding is exhausted, is a promised gift and will be bequeathed to the Argentine State.**

Federico conceived the entire structure in the last century, concerned with finding the legal form that would give continuity to what he was offering society: that his original impulse would not die out with his physical departure. The funding was—and is—ample, but finite.

Our Federico was a visionary; that is why, so often, when faced with new questions we return to him, to the Statutes of the Foundation that he himself drafted, or to the heartfelt words of his will, where we find many answers. Accepting changes and transitions is also a way of answering; so, even, is deferring a problem, trusting in a possible future in which we may address it with other tools.

II. How We Came to Faivovich & Goldberg

In 2025, the ANBA invited the artistic duo to take part in the Trabucco Prize in the "Other Media" category, which is held every four years with Klemm as its venue. (To think that that project was this very work we see installed here today is to recall a key moment in our collision-coalition.)

A 41-kilogram meteorite encapsulated in wood, its opening date set for the year 2105, when it will once again be offered as a donation to the Argentine Scientific Society.

The history of the piece begins in 2016, when the artists offered the meteorite to the Argentine Scientific Society and the offer did not prosper. In 2018, at a public ceremony at arteBA, they encapsulated the object and transferred the decision to the future, not as a gesture of defeat but as a way of pushing responsibility for heritage into the future; in their own words, "to build a work that unfolds its own meaning over time."

Faivovich & Goldberg designed a system of septennia spanning more than eighty years of successive institutional custodies—with blockchain traceability—to carry the piece to "its appointment" in the future and, in some way, as Federico did in his time, to delegate and share responsibility with the State, at some point in the future.

The work is also a commitment to institutional rotation, an agreement of shared care. That premise earned it, in 2025, a "new" refusal to take part in the Trabucco Prize, and the project had to be modified; but it resonated forcefully in me, because of my years of research on "the futures of collections" and because, suddenly, I saw a clock beginning to sound, in Klemm's own building, a loud, resonant ticking that brings us together today.

Encountering this piece and its history was my own eureka and, at the same time, the metaphor of the meteorite colliding with Klemm. A crash made itself heard: **the clock is running**.

I began to imagine this presence in the gallery as our "transitional object," one that can help us think through our institutional communication regarding the legacy.

A work that travels toward the future through a chain of custodies is the best image available for speaking about what will happen at Klemm.

We discussed it with the entire team of the Foundation and allowed ourselves to be "affected"—in the double sense of affection and affect—by the analogous operation of the piece and the collection, by these temporal coincidences.

Through the ANBA, the Trabucco Prize in the "Other Media" category is held at Klemm. That is why the arrival of this chronometer—the *Escala Pro Tempore*, this bar that exudes time—positions and impacts us: it makes us see a collection advancing toward its own transition to the State.

III. The Specular

Another powerful metaphor is the force the piece exerts on the architecture here in the basement, on the Fundación Klemm column.

When the version that ultimately took part in the Trabucco was installed in 2025, the artists used the *Escala Pro Tempore*—the iron bar we see today—and, as the first object and support, fitted a metal ring around the column, which today bears the name *Un anillo para la Fundación Klemm* [A Ring for Fundación Klemm]. I saw it at once as the sealing of a temporal pact: a metal that bursts in (like the meteorite) and, at the same time, seems always to have been there, embracing the architecture. A body that installs itself and installs questions.

The shape of the ring immediately brought to mind *La Main heureuse* (1955), one of the most representative works by René Magritte in the Collection, in which a small yet immense diamond ring embraces a piano—which, within its own fiction, it manages to contain. *La Main heureuse* is also the title of an opera by Schoenberg (1913); times interweave and meet.

Klemm does not own the meteorite—it cares for it for one septennium—nor is it the owner of the Collection; it is the custodial institution: in both cases, what is exercised is a *pro tempore* custody. It is a call to attend to our coming transition: it will be in twenty years, perhaps in thirty. Neither the timeframe nor the amount of funding is disclosed to those of us who manage the Collection and the Foundation. It is a great act of trust. Even believing that there is a meteorite in the capsule is an act of trust. These are wills that meet in sharing care and responsibilities.

We may understand the word responsibility, as our dear Donna Haraway proposes, as *response-ability*: the ability to respond. Thus, the passage of the Collection to the Argentine State and that of the meteorite to the Scientific Society would not be closures, but rather our ability to give beginning to new eras.

IV. What Is a Collection-Museum in the Contemporary Moment?

Part of what we are doing here is a typical museum operation: registering a loan, signing contracts, documenting.

The museum is associated with the idea of enduring through legacies. Heritage consists of legacies manifested mostly in objects that are inherited and treasured for posterity. But what if collections were made up more of performative energy, whose legacy would be "to transmit knowledge responsibly"? Can we envision legacies passed on as they were in the past, like oral narratives or apprenticeships?

We are now called by an idea of retro-future: retracing the steps that were hastened in faith in progress and that now deserve to be reexamined. When Federico conceived his legacy, the State had a weight and a power that, in the near future, appear to be cracking. Can the idea of keeping treasures for the future be dismantled? Can there be collections of pure present, or museums of immediacy?

The twentieth-century avant-gardes, through an artistic practice charged with institutional critique, had already gathered several options: Marcel Duchamp's portable museum, the *Boîte-en-valise*, with handmade miniature copies of his own works; André Malraux's celebrated imaginary museum, which anyone can build for themselves out of images; Marcel Broodthaers's fictitious museum, which exists only because an artist pronounces it. And later, the empty museum, the museum of nothing, Douglas Crimp's museum in ruins, Paul Preciado's switched-off museum, and L'Internationale's museums of the commons: institutions that open their collections to new forms of shared governance, that actively "uncollect" and question the model of eternal growth.

In Paul Preciado's words:

> …while it is by now history that, since the early twentieth century, with the corrosive yet unfinished actions of the avant-gardes against the museum institution, museums have been characterized and caricatured as static mausoleums, we also know that for decades these cultural spaces have been engaged in a process of constant self-critique regarding their social functions […] museums can be exceptional sites of enunciation so that, far from ossifying hegemonic discourses and consolidating spaces of exclusivity, they make room for other voices and amplify their echoes and resonances…

It is worth recalling, moreover, that at the matrix of museums lies conquest: the cultural extractivism that filled their galleries and storerooms with the goods of "others." Today, when many of these institutions are restituting material to their

communities of origin, it is a good moment to rethink the modes of existence of the collection-museum institution.

We have spoken of trust, and in the contemporary moment many institutions do not enjoy it. Many artists' families, faced with the instability of institutions, hesitate to donate their archives or legacies. From a certain domain of my personal experience in collections management, I know what goes on backstage: inventories always unfinished, records always fragmentary, ghost cataloguing with incomplete or bias-laden descriptors that hinder search and discovery; lever-arch files piling up to infinity; databases under the constant threat of technological obsolescence and its migrations; movement controls and risk management dependent on staff.

That experience produces an uncomfortable certainty: **accumulating is not the same as activating**. And the relevant question is: to grow or not to grow? Will we need more space, more acquisitions or donations? It would seem that we cannot produce another institutional language for the museum… Museums ought to be encouraged to build twenty-first-century collecting strategies, temporary custodies, and shared care, instead of repeating the old pattern based on the idea of eternal growth.

Caring for the stewardship of cultural goods or practices, caring for the implications of becoming heritage, would already be an ecological politics that allows us to imagine other forms. The energy of artistic collectives and of the artwork as practice, as sensibilities that are neither personalist nor hegemonic, can serve as a lure toward an unexplored path: that of a museum of tomorrow that relearns how to collect and uncollect at the pace at which the contemporary world moves, with a fluidity of categories that in turn demands flexibility in processes; in this case, in collections management.

For the temporary custody of the meteorite, then, we wish to propose a different framework.

V. Three Wagers for the Coming Years

1. An annual colloquium. The meteorite will be with us for seven years. Seven years are seven opportunities to hold an open gathering that brings together and takes up again all the questions the work raises: How is the time of a heritage in transition governed? How does one document what has not yet happened? What responsibilities does a public institution inherit when it receives a private collection? Who guards the custodian?

Each edition will pose its own questions, and we envision hybrid gatherings, with guests from different fields: a unit that accumulates thought, network, and documentation over the course of the septennium.

2. Adolescents and university alliances. The program for adolescents already running at Klemm is not a complementary activity: it is one of the most strategic wagers we have. Opening participation in the colloquium to the adolescents who take part in our programs will be key. The work of audience development begins now. The alliances with the University of Buenos Aires (UBA), the Universidad Nacional de San Martín (UNSAM) and its Centro de Estudios Espigas, the Universidad Torcuato Di Tella (UTDT), and the Museo del Cine of the City of Buenos Aires are already part of the fabric of the community that is growing and that will sustain the legacy when the current legal form no longer exists.

3. A Friends of the Future Association. A strategy of "anti-oblivion relays." It would not be a conventional Friends association; it is not about fundraising to extend the funding, but about community to protect Federico's driving ideas: *the Prize for young artists, free admission, the educational programs, and guaranteed access to the Archive*. These are the ideas we would like to reach the State along with the works. A Friends of the Future Association looks toward those futures in which Klemm multiplies, becomes kaleidoscopic, radiating toward all the national museums that will receive the Collection—and what better way than with a community that already knows it and cares for it.

Each year during the septennium of custody, adolescents in the annual program will be able to take part in the Colloquium to imagine the futures of collections.

Drawing to a Close…

Federico designed every forward-looking mechanism he could conceive at the time so that continuity would be active. He died so young, at sixty, when the foundation was barely seven years old and its collection was still growing. He bequeathed us a foundation with work to be done and a plan for when he was no longer here. These three wagers are our way of doing that work.

The piece (the meteorite) will be cared for like any other in the Collection: it may be exhibited, lent, included in gallery tours or in visits to the open storage… The contract is a standard legal instrument, but in this case it was, at the same time, the logbook of a working path toward thinking this project through together. It is a piece that, despite its silence inside the box, holds a high dose of potential performativity.

This October 1, much more happened here than was planned: the mounting of this piece as a method implies that meaning is not given in advance; it emerges from the gesture of assembling fragments. This afternoon we assembled a few: the meteorite, the loan agreement, the Foundation, the possible colloquia, the Friends of the Future Association, the educational programs. None of them makes sense alone; Faivovich & Goldberg's work proposes to us today this choreography, this present-now: a finite alliance to organize ourselves, to think, and to activate shorter but impactful futures, with deeply significant affects and effects, like those Federico Klemm imagined.

We take up the challenge almost as an athletic goal: **to meet every October 1 of the coming septennium**, trained to converse and to imagine new ways of carrying this torch forward, and carrying it better.

Thank you very much.

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